AASHNA KHURANA, Ph.D.

Post-doctoral Fellow at the University of Texas at Austin

aashna.khurana@austin.utexas.edu | Website: https://akhurana.com

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Inclusive and Special Education; Special Education Policy and Service Delivery; Teacher Capacity and Preparation for Inclusion; Educational Leadership, School Improvement and Change; Systems Evaluation; Systemwide Inclusion Reform; Research-Practice Partnerships.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Curriculum and Instruction (and Educational Leadership) 2026

Lynch School of Education and Human Development, Boston College

Dissertation: Realist Evaluation of Inclusive Special Education Reform in the Archdiocese of Milwaukee

M.Ed., Special Education 2018

Department of Special Education, S.N.D.T. Women's University, Mumbai, India

B.Ed., Special Education 2015

Lady Irwin College, Delhi University, New Delhi, India

B.Comm. (Honours) 2014

Delhi University, New Delhi, India

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

Laura Bassi Scholarship Spring 2026, Editorial Assistance

David L. Clark Scholar (2026). Sponsored by UCEA and Divisions A and L, AERA. Competitive national fellowship recognizing emerging scholars in educational leadership.

Roche Center Research Fellowship (2025–2026). $5,000 fellowship with research travel support to conduct and publish scholarship on Catholic schools. Lynch School of Education, Boston College.

Jackson Scholar (2024–2026). University Council for Educational Administration (UCEA). Recognizes doctoral students advancing equity-focused educational research.

UCEA Graduate Student Fellowship (2025). Collaborative fellowship with the UCEA Joint Program Center for the Study of the Superintendency & District Governance, under Dr. Meredith Mountford, Florida Atlantic University and Dr. Leigh Wallace, University of Wisconsin, Milwaukee.

ICSEI Junior Scholar Fellowship (2025). Prestigious fellowship recognizing emerging scholars in educational research from the International Congress for School Effectiveness and Improvement.

Best Paper Nomination (2022). New England Educational Research Organization (NEERO) Annual Conference. Paper: "System Efforts to Reform Special Education Service Delivery in Boston Public Schools."

Researcher Development Program Fellow (2022–2023). UCEA-AERA Leadership for School Improvement SIG program.

Inclusive Learning Network Award (2021). International Society for Technology in Education (ISTE) PLN. Honored for contributions to inclusive learning practices.

PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

Khurana, A. (under review). Inclusion as an Emergent Property of the System: Unpacking system-level conditions for sustain special education reform in Catholic schools. *Journal of Educational Change*

Khurana, A. & Gates, E. (under preparation). Realist approach as a methodology for studying school improvement for students with disabilities. *American Journal of Evaluation*. (Q1, IF 2.2)

Khurana, A. & Quesnell, D, Anderson, M. (under preparation). The Making of an Inclusive School: A Case of a Catholic School. *Journal of Cases in Educational Leadership* (Q1)

Khurana, A. (in press). From fragmentation to cohesion: A narrative review of system-level inclusive education reforms. *Journal of Special Education Leadership.* (Q3, SJR-0.284)

Scanlan M, **Khurana A**, Martin T, Melendez C (2026), "Mentoring coaches toward communities of practice advancing inclusion". *International Journal of Mentoring and Coaching in Education*, Vol. 15 No. 3 pp. 292–306, doi: https://doi.org/10.1108/IJMCE-09-2025-0139 (Q2, IF-1.8)

Khurana, A. (2022, September). Converting physical spaces into learning spaces: Integrating universal design and universal design for learning. *Frontiers in Education, 7*, Article 965818. https://doi.org/10.3389/feduc.2022.965818. (Q2, IF-1.9)

Book Chapters

Mountford, M., Wallace, L. E., & **Khurana, A.** (in press). Wicked problems: Conceptual foundations and contemporary significance. In M. Mountford & L. E. Wallace (Eds.), *School boards and superintendents: Navigating a wicked terrain* (Research on the superintendency series, Vol. 3).

Mountford, M., Wallace, L. E., & **Khurana, A.** (in press). Wicked is as wicked does. In M. Mountford & L. E. Wallace (Eds.), *School boards and superintendents: Navigating a wicked terrain* (Research on the superintendency series, Vol. 3).

Mountford, M., Wallace, L. E., & **Khurana, A.** (in press). No rest from the wicked. In M. Mountford & L. E. Wallace (Eds.), *School boards and superintendents: Navigating a wicked terrain* (Research on the superintendency series, Vol. 3).

Khurana, A., & Scanlan, M. (2025). Reforming special education service delivery in Boston Public Schools with research-practice partnership. In K. Zenkov, D. Polly, & L. Rudder (Eds.), *Boundary-spanning in school-university partnerships.* Information Age Publishing.

Khurana, A., Scanlan, M., Bott, J., & d'Ablemont Burnes, E. (2023). Research–practice partnership to reform special education service delivery in Boston Public Schools. In J. Barnes, M. J. Stevens, B. Z. Ekelund, & K. Perham-Lippman (Eds.), *Inclusive leadership: Equity and belonging in our communities* (pp. 107–120). Emerald.

Dalton, E. M., Jackson, R. M., Bracken, S., Satar, A. A., Aabi, M., **Khurana, A**., Nicholas, L., Power, O. K., & Plantin Ewe, L. (2023). Creating an international collaboratory for leadership in universally designed education: INCLUDE as a global community of practice. In K. Koreeda, M. Tsuge, S. Ikuta, E. M. Dalton, & L. Plantin Ewe (Eds.), *Building inclusive education in K-12 classrooms and higher education: Theories and principles* (pp. 1–20). IGI Global. https://doi.org/10.4018/978-1-6684-7370-2.ch001

Khurana, A. (2019). UDL practices in India: Paving a path from equality to equity in learning. In S. L. Gronseth & E. M. Dalton (Eds.), *Universal access through inclusive instructional design: International perspectives on UDL* (pp. 103–110). Routledge.

Conference Papers and Presentations

Khurana, A. (2026, April). *Transforming systems for inclusion: Advancing reform for students with disabilities* [Paper presentation]. American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting, Los Angeles, CA, USA.

Khurana, A. (2026, April). *Unpacking system-level conditions for sustained reform in Catholic schools* [Paper presentation]. American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting, Los Angeles, CA, USA.

Khurana, A. (2026, March). *Beyond isolated practices: A systemic four-part framework for inclusive education reform* [Poster presentation]. Council for Exceptional Children Annual Conference, Salt Lake City, UT, USA.

Khurana, A. (2026, January). *What makes inclusion "sticky"? Unpacking system-level conditions for sustained reform in Catholic schools* [Paper presentation]. International Congress for School Effectiveness and Improvement (ICSEI), Doha, Qatar.

Khurana, A. (2025, November). *Leading inclusive reform: Building resilience through collaboration and community* [Paper presentation]. Graduate Student Symposium (GSS), University Council for Educational Administration (UCEA) Annual Convention, San Juan, Puerto Rico.

Khurana, A. (2025, November). *Examining system-level variation in inclusive education across Catholic schools* [Symposium presentation]. Jackson Scholars Symposium, University Council for Educational Administration (UCEA) Annual Convention, San Juan, Puerto Rico.

Khurana, A. (2025, April). *Examining system-level variation in inclusive education across Catholic schools* [Symposium presentation]. Jackson Scholars Symposium, American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting, Denver, CO, USA.

Khurana, A. (2025, March). *Advancing deep equity in education systems: A narrative review of school-research partnerships for systemic transformation* [Paper presentation]. New England Educational Research Organization (NEERO) Annual Conference, Newport, NH, USA.

Khurana, A. (2026, March). *Leading for lasting inclusion: System reform in Catholic school networks* [Poster presentation]. Council for Exceptional Children Annual Conference, Salt Lake City, UT, USA.

Khurana, A. (2025, January). *System-level inclusive reform: Advancing educational equity for students with disabilities through intersectional approaches* [Paper presentation]. International Conference on Education 3, Mumbai, India.

Khurana, A., & Scanlan, M. (2025, March). *Building equitable leadership through targeted coaching: Supporting systems change for inclusive education in Boston Public Schools* [Paper presentation]. New England Educational Research Organization (NEERO) Annual Conference, Newport, NH, USA.

Khurana, A. (2025, February). *Transforming education systems: A review of systems reform for equity and justice for children with disabilities* [Poster session]. International Congress for School Effectiveness and Improvement (ICSEI), Melbourne, Australia.

Khurana, A. (2025, February). *Systems change efforts for inclusive education: Lessons from effective districts* [Dialogic session]. International Congress for School Effectiveness and Improvement (ICSEI), Melbourne, Australia.

Khurana, A., & Scanlan, M. (2024, June). Advancing educational equity: System-level inclusive reforms through Universal Design for Learning. Lightning talk at the International Conference on Equity and Quality (ICEQ), Worcester, UK.

Khurana, A. (2024, June). Cross-pollination of Universal Design for Learning and neurodiversity frameworks to improve opportunities for expression of learning. Paper presented at ICEQ, Worcester, UK.

Plantin Ewe, L., **Khurana, A.,** & Dalton, E. (2024, June). Universal Design for Learning: What is the research evidence? A systematic review. Poster at ICEQ, Worcester, UK.

Scanlan, M., & **Khurana, A.** (2024, April). A research-practice partnership for dismantling social injustices and advancing organizational transformation for inclusive education. AERA Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

Scanlan, M., & **Khurana, A.** (2024, January). A research-practice partnership advancing organizational transformation for inclusive education. ICSEI Annual Conference, Dublin, Ireland.

Khurana, A., Richardson, J., & Choi, J. H. (2023, November). Facilitating school-wide inclusion: A continuous improvement framework for systemic educational reform. UCEA Annual Convention, Minneapolis, MN.

Khurana, A., & Scanlan, M. (2023, May). System efforts to reform special education service delivery in Boston Public Schools. NEERO Annual Conference, Newport, NH.

Khurana, A., & Scanlan, M. (2023, April). A systemic inquiry of how school-based inclusion planning teams reform special education service delivery: A case of Boston Public Schools. AERA Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL.

Dyer, C., **Khurana, A.,** Sharma, G., Ramanujan, P., & Bhattacharjea, S. (2021). Pathways to numeracy: A comparative analysis of policy and curricular materials for early years' mathematics in three states of India. Comparative and International Education Society (CIES).

Dalton, E., & **Khurana, A.** (2020). Making assessments inclusive. In D. Schmidt-Crawford (Ed.), *Proceedings of Society for Information Technology & Teacher Education International Conference* (pp. 1975–1979). AACE.

Khurana, A., & Apoorva, P. (2019). Relearning of the teachers: Effect of training in Universal Design for Learning on teacher's knowledge and skills and learners' achievement. *Proceedings of Society for Information Technology & Teacher Education International Conference* (pp. 1471–1481). AACE.

Dalton, E., Gronseth, S., Anderson, C., Anderson, K., & **Khurana, A.** (2019). Inclusive instructional design efforts around the world. In K. Graziano (Ed.), *Proceedings of Society for Information Technology & Teacher Education International Conference* (pp. 2579–2581). AACE.

Web posts and Blogposts

Dyer, C., Bhattacharjea, S., Ramanujan, P., **Khurana, A.,** & Alcott, B. (2023). Continuity, discontinuity, and progression in the early years' numeracy curriculum in India. *Ideas for India.*

Khurana, A. (2020, June 1). E-learning challenges in India. *International Collaboratory for Leadership in Universally Designed Education (INCLUDE) Blog.* https://include.wp.worc.ac.uk/5-2-e-learning-challenges-in-india/

Khurana, A. (2022, May 25). *Episode 9: Talking flexible learning spaces* (M. Flood, Host) [Audio podcast episode]. In *Talking about all things inclusion*. https://margaretfloodudl.com/2022/05/25/episode-9-talking-flexible-learning-spaces-with-aashna-khurana/

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral Fellow – Educational Leadership and Policy, College of Education, University of Texas at Austin, Fall 2026 - Present

- Leading a professional development initiative with San Antonio Independent School District that prepares school principals to use evidence-based special education practices and to support the inclusion of students with disabilities.
- Conducting an independent study of instructional leadership in Dallas Independent School District with Dr. Sarah Powell and Dr. David DeMatthews, examining how the district supports schools and how schools build intervention structures for students with disabilities.
- Conducting a literature review on district improvement.
- Preparing five to six manuscripts for publication as sole author, with Dr. DeMatthews, and with the wider research team on current projects.

Consultant, ENABLE Project, Pratham Education Foundation, September 2026 - Present

- Lead technical quality and coherence across the inclusive education content portfolio, from development and review through adaptation and sign-off.
- Embed Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles across curriculum, pedagogy, learning materials and assessments, and strengthen existing resources for accessibility and usability.
- Develop training and capacity-building materials for teachers, Anganwadi workers, special educators and community workers, and build the inclusive education team's capacity through mentoring, technical reviews and workshops.
- Provide technical inputs to new program design, author frameworks, guidelines and tools, and coordinate with internal teams and external partners across the inclusive education ecosystem.

Consultant, Ministry of Education, Government of India, June 2026 - Present

- Developed national training modules on Universal Design for Learning (UDL), Specially Designed Instruction (SDI), and High-Leverage Practices (HLPs) for master trainers, with state and district rollout beginning October 2026.
- Designed the inclusive lesson plan template for nationwide use in public schools, with a lesson design framework and teacher checklist.
- Authored exemplar lessons modeling evidence-based instructional strategies.
- Advise on the Ministry's inclusive education agenda, focusing on neurodiversity and teacher preparation.

Dissertation Research – Boston College, Fall 2025 – Spring 2026

- Conducted a realist evaluation of inclusive education reform in the Archdiocese of Milwaukee, examining why some Catholic schools more successfully enroll and include students with disabilities.

- Identified key system-level conditions that sustain inclusive practice.
- Developed individual school summaries to support the schools in their ongoing inclusion effort

Research–Practice Partnership with Boston Public Schools Administrators, **2022–2025**

- Worked with district administrators to refine a theory of action for the inclusion of students with disabilities.
- Co-developed a suite of practitioner tools, including an inclusion planning guidebook, an evaluation tool, and classroom observation instruments.
- Supported professional development for inclusion coaches, provided individualized support.
- Authored academic publications from the partnership and presented at conferences.

Research (Assessment) Associate – ASER Center, Pratham Education Foundation, India , 2018–2021

- Led the design and development of the Assessment for All (AfA) tool, grounded in Universal Design for Learning principles, to evaluate the learning levels of children with disabilities across 16 regional languages.
- Conducted large-scale surveys and cognitive labs to validate assessment design.
- Developed national assessment instruments, including the ASER 2019 tool and the PAL-ELANA tool, used across 13 low- and middle-income countries.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University Teaching

1. ***Teaching Fellow, EDUC7438: Educating Children with Disabilities, USA, Fall 2024 – Summer 2025***

Lynch School of Education and Human Development, Boston College

Facilitated seminars, developed course materials, mentored graduate students in special education theory and practice.

2. ***Guest Lecturer, T560: Universal Design for Learning: Theory, Practice, and Innovation, Harvard University Graduate School of Education, USA. (Annual Invitation, 2025-2026)***

3. ***Guest Lecturer, Instructional Technology & Society, University of Houston College of Education, USA. (February 2020 & 2024)***

4. Guest Lecturer, Developing Leadership Capacity Through Reflective Practice, Royal Roads University, Victoria, Canada. (2021)

K–12 Teaching Experience

Special Educator, DAV Public School, New Delhi, India, 2015–2016

Elementary Educator, Kendriya Vidyalaya (Central School of India), New Delhi, India, 2014–2015

SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

Professional Organizations

Co-Chair, Generational Renewal, Inclusion and Diversity (GRID) Committee, ICSEI, 2025–Present

Co-Chair, Division A Connect Series, American Educational Research Association (AERA), 2025–Present

Consultant, Pratham Education Foundation, 2024–Present

Graduate Student Representative, Leadership for School Improvement SIG, AERA & Researcher Development Program, UCEA, 2023–2025

UDL Summer Intern, Center for Applied Special Technologies (CAST), (2022)

Steering Committee Member, InCLUDE (International Collaboratory for Leadership in Universally Designed Education), 2019–2025

Co-Chair, SITE Universal Design for Learning (UDL) Special Interest Group, 2021–2023

LANGUAGE PROFICIENCY

German, B2.1 Level (Intermediate)

English (Fluent)

Hindi (Fluent)